

Potential data mishaps and the risks of ignoring them

Risk area	Description	Real-world impact
Data breaches and cyber attacks	Weak security measures lead to unauthorised access, data theft, or ransomware.	Loss of sensitive data, legal action, and reputational damage (e.g., Air India security breach).
Regulatory non-compliance	Failure to meet legal data obligations under laws like DPDP, GDPR, etc.	Heavy fines, legal notices, operational restrictions (e.g., Meta fined under GDPR).
Loss of customer trust	Insecure or misused data erodes public confidence and loyalty.	Reduced user base, lower engagement, and drop in brand value.
Inaccurate decision-making	Poor data quality leads to flawed insights, forecasting errors, and bias.	Wrong investments, ineffective campaigns, and strategic missteps.
Operational inefficiency	Disorganised or duplicated data wastes employee time and increases cost.	Delayed reporting, repeated errors, manual correction workload.
Internal data misuse	Lack of governance allows unauthorised employee access or accidental leaks.	Insider threats, data leaks, and employee misconduct.
System downtime and data loss	Inadequate backups or disaster recovery planning result in data unavailability.	Interrupted services, revenue loss, and data recovery costs.

Best data management practices for organisations

Best practice	Description	Actionable steps
Build a data-first culture	Promote data awareness and responsibility across all levels of the organisation.	Conduct data literacy training; promote data-backed decisions; reward usage
Balance accessibility with security	Ensure data is available to the right people while staying protected from misuse.	Implement role-based access control (RBAC); use multi-factor authentication (MFA); encrypt sensitive data
Establish a governance framework	Create policies, roles, and standards for consistent and compliant data handling.	Assign data owners and stewards; standardise data formats and definitions; document policies clearly
Automate data management tasks	Reduce manual workload and human error through automation tools.	Use ETL/ELT pipelines; automate data cleaning; schedule regular backups
Stay compliant with regulations	Ensure ongoing alignment with laws like DPDP, GDPR, and CCPA.	Monitor legal updates; maintain audit trails; conduct privacy impact assessments
Invest in the right tools and tech	Adopt modern data platforms, analytics tools, and security systems.	Use data lakes/warehouses; deploy DLP tools; implement a data catalogue
Encourage cross-team collaboration	Foster alignment between data, IT, security, and business teams.	Hold governance meetings; share insights dashboards; form incident task forces

will allow organisations to automate routine data tasks, such as data entry, reconciliation, and data validation. In tandem with task automation, human talent will be deployed for higher-value, analytical tasks and not routine transactions.

Intelligent automation means that instead of being reactive, data management will be proactive. Innovative automation technologies will continuously monitor data for an anomaly, raise a flag

if data needs to be cleaned up, or signal a compliance risk in real-time.

In an interconnected world driven by data, data management and security are no longer optional considerations, but are critical to the organisation's overall success. When data is managed

well, it can be used as a source of reliable insights; when it is well-secured, it can be trusted by customers, partners, and regulators; and when both of these disciplines align, data becomes the game changer that leads to smarter decisions and faster innovation. **END** 

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